

Validation Plan — 5 Contractor Interviews

Winch · 18 September 2026 · Companion to "Quote Recovery Opportunity Assessment v2.0"

Markets: United Kingdom & Ireland · Europe · Australia · wider EMEA

Purpose. Before writing significant code, establish whether the two load-bearing assumptions under Winch survive contact with five real trade contractors. Everything else in the assessment is either already evidenced or cheap to change later. These two are neither.

1. What is being tested

Hypothesis A — the non-adoption thesis

Claim: Contractors in this segment either already own quote follow-up automation and do not use it, or would not configure it if handed it — because configuring it is desk work they will not do.

Why it matters: The entire repositioning rests on this. If it turns out contractors simply lack the feature, we are competing head-on with Jobber and ServiceM8 on capability and price, which is a far worse business. If it turns out they own it and never switched it on, our wedge — zero onboarding, inside an app already open — is the whole product.

Confirmed if: 3 or more of 5 already pay for software with follow-up capability they have never configured, or abandoned after trying.

Killed if: 3 or more of 5 have working, self-configured follow-up already running and report it as adequate.

Hypothesis B — will they answer the gate?

Claim: A contractor will reliably respond to an agent's approval prompt outside working hours; and if they will not, front-loaded approval with a veto window is acceptable to them.

Why it matters: This is the core interaction design. Strict per-message gating is safest legally and reputationally, but if contractors do not answer prompts, the sequence stalls and we have rebuilt the original problem while charging for it. This decides the graph topology, so it must be settled before the LangGraph work starts.

Confirmed if: 4 or more of 5 respond to the live prompt test (section 5) within 12 hours, **or** 4 or more of 5 explicitly accept veto-window approval when the tradeoff is explained plainly.

Killed if: contractors both ignore prompts **and** reject pre-approval as too risky for their reputation. That combination means no safe design exists at this price point, and the product needs rethinking.

Secondary questions — answer if the conversation allows, never at the expense of A and B

- What actually happens to a quote after it is sent? Walk the real sequence.
- Baseline numbers: quotes sent per month, rough win rate, typical value.
- Do they know which quotes went cold, or is it invisible to them?
- Which invoicing or accounting tool, and is it actually reconciled or just for the accountant?
- Is WhatsApp genuinely their working channel, or only personal?
- What do their customers answer — SMS, WhatsApp, phone, email?
- What would make them look bad in front of a customer? Listen for the reputational red lines.

2. Who to recruit

Five contractors, one per row. Deliberately spread across geography and trade so a single local quirk cannot masquerade as a finding. Every one must quote jobs above the five-figure threshold and be the person who writes the quotes.

#	Market	Trade profile	Why this slot
1	UK (non-metro: East Anglia, Yorkshire, South West, Mid Wales)	Agricultural or commercial fencing, groundworks	Primary market; Xero/Sage territory; dense supplier networks for later channel partnerships
2	UK or Ireland	Steel-frame buildings, barn or shed construction	Highest ticket value in the segment; longest decision cycles, so dormancy is most visible
3	Australia (regional NSW, QLD or WA)	Shed builder, borehole/water-well driller, or ag fabricator	Second primary market; validates that findings are not UK-specific; ServiceM8/Tradify culture already present
4	EU (Ireland, Netherlands, Spain, Portugal or Poland)	Heavy equipment mechanic or ag fabricator	Tests whether the wedge survives a different invoicing stack and language
5	Wider EMEA (South Africa or UAE)	Fencing, civils subcontract, or plant maintenance	WhatsApp is unambiguously the default business channel here; upper bound on channel fit

Hard screening criteria. They must (a) personally write the quotes, (b) quote jobs above roughly GBP 8k / EUR 10k / AUD 15k, (c) run a business of ten field staff or fewer, and (d) have sent at least five quotes in the last 60 days. If someone has an office manager who chases quotes, they are out — that is a different business with a different problem.

3. How to find them

- **Supplier and merchant route (best quality).** Steel stockists, timber merchants, fencing wholesalers, plant dealers. Ask the trade counter manager which of their account customers quote big jobs. This doubles as early channel-partner discovery.
- **Trade associations and federations.** UK: FMB, NFU county branches, regional fencing and agricultural contractor associations. AU: Master Builders state branches, regional ag contractor groups. Ireland and EU: equivalent national bodies.
- **Regional trade Facebook groups and WhatsApp communities.** Post asking for 30 minutes, not a sale. This is where this persona actually congregates.
- **Physical presence.** Regional agricultural shows, plant and machinery auctions, county trade days. Twenty minutes at a merchant's trade counter at 7am beats a week of cold email.
- **Warm chains.** Ask every interviewee for one introduction at the end. Expect this to supply slots 4 and 5.

Do not recruit through paid ads, LinkedIn InMail, or generic B2B panels. You will get metro-based, digitally-fluent operators who are not the persona, and the findings will be confidently wrong.

4. The outreach message

Send by WhatsApp or SMS, never email. Keep it under six lines. Offer money — their time is genuinely scarce and paying for it filters for seriousness on both sides.

Hi [Name] — [Referrer] gave me your number. I'm researching how contractors handle quote follow-ups on bigger jobs. Not selling anything. 30 minutes on the phone, and I'll send you GBP 50 / a fuel voucher for your time. Any evening this week or Sunday suit?

Notes. Name the referrer in the first eight words — it is the only thing carrying the message. "Not selling anything" must be literally true for the whole call. Offer evenings and Sundays, because that is when this persona is reachable, and their willingness to take a Sunday call is itself a data point about Hypothesis B.

5. The interview — 30 to 40 minutes

Record with permission. Do not demo. Do not describe the product until section 5.4, and then only as a sketch.

5.1 Warm-up — 5 minutes

Get them talking about the work, not the software. What are they quoting at the moment, how big, how far out is the schedule. You are establishing that you understand the trade, and loosening them up before the questions that matter.

5.2 Walk the last quote — 10 minutes

The most valuable ten minutes of the call. Ask them to open their phone and walk you through the **most recent quote over [threshold] that they sent and have not heard back on**. Not a hypothetical — a real one, on screen.

- When did you send it, and how? PDF by email, photo of a written sheet, something else?
- What did you do after you hit send? Walk me through it.
- Has anyone followed up? Who, when, what did they say?
- How would you know today whether that job is alive or dead?
- What usually happens to one like this?

Listen for the moment they say some version of *"if they want it, they'll ring me."* Note whether it is said with confidence or with resignation — the two imply very different products.

5.3 The software audit — 8 minutes (Hypothesis A)

Ask them to open whatever they use — Xero, Sage, QuickBooks, ServiceM8, Tradify, Jobber, a spreadsheet, a notebook. On screen, not from memory.

- What do you pay for, and what do you actually open in a normal week?
- Did anyone set it up for you, or did you do it yourself?
- Has anything in there ever chased a customer for you automatically? Do you know whether it can?
- If the answer is yes but it is off: what stopped you turning it on?
- Have you ever started setting something like that up and given up? What made you stop?

Record the literal answer to "what stopped you." Whether the reason is time, confusion, distrust, or never knowing the feature existed determines the pitch, and each implies a different message.

5.4 The prompt test — 5 minutes (Hypothesis B)

Describe the mechanic in plain language. No jargon, no mention of AI, agents or LangGraph.

"Imagine you forward that PDF to a WhatsApp number. A few seconds later it comes back: *'Fencing job for Mark Henderson, GBP 24,500. I'll send him a friendly check-in on Thursday and a schedule nudge next Tuesday — want me to?'* You reply yes, and it handles it. If Mark replies with a question, it stops everything and tells you to ring him."

Then ask, in this order, and do not soften the second question:

- 1 Would you forward the PDF? Why or why not?
- 2 **If that message landed at nine on a Sunday night, hand on heart — would you answer it, or would you see it and deal with it later?**
- 3 If you would not answer every time: would you rather approve the whole sequence upfront when you send the quote, and get a heads-up two hours before each text goes out that you can stop? Or does that feel like losing control?
- 4 What would this thing have to never do, for you to let it text your customers?

Question 4 surfaces the reputational red lines. Write the answers down verbatim; they become guardrails in the system prompt and the product spec.

5.5 The live offer — 5 minutes

Close every interview with the single-fold demo offer, regardless of how the call went:

"Pick one quote from the last two months that went cold. I'll run a three-step text sequence on it myself, free, and show you every message before it goes. If they reply, we talk. If nothing happens, you've lost nothing."

Whether they say yes is the single strongest signal in the whole exercise — stronger than anything they say about willingness to pay. Verbal enthusiasm is cheap; handing you a real customer's phone number is not.

6. What to capture

One row per interview, filled in within an hour of the call while it is still fresh.

Field	Capture
Identity	Market, trade, crew size, who writes quotes
Volume	Quotes per month, typical value, rough win rate
Dormancy	Quotes sent in last 60 days with no outcome either way
Current follow-up	What actually happens after send — verbatim
Software stack	What they pay for; what they open weekly; who set it up
Hyp. A	Owens follow-up capability? Configured? If not — the literal reason
Hyp. B	Would answer a Sunday-night prompt: yes / honestly no / "later". Accepts veto-window: yes / no
Red lines	What the agent must never do — verbatim
Live offer	Accepted / declined. If accepted: customer name and quote value
Channel	Their channel; their customers' channel

Field	Capture
Price reaction	Unprompted only. Never ask what they would pay.

7. Decision rules

Run all five before deciding anything. Do not adjust the product mid-sequence — five interviews against a fixed set of questions is the point.

Outcome	What it means	Action
A confirmed, B confirmed (prompts answered)	Thesis holds; strict per-message gating is viable	Build the demo as specified. Strict <code>interrupt()</code> on every send.
A confirmed, B confirmed (via veto acceptance)	Thesis holds; contractors will not babysit prompts	Build with front-loaded approval and veto window. Most likely outcome — plan for it.
A confirmed, B killed	They want it, but no safe control design is acceptable to them	Do not build the agent yet. Consider the managed-service version: a human runs the sequences under the contractor's brand, priced higher, validating demand before automating.
A killed, B either	They have working follow-up and are content	Stop. The wedge is not real. Re-examine the segment or the problem.
Fewer than 3 clean interviews	Recruitment failed, not the thesis	Re-recruit through a different channel before concluding anything.

Stop-the-line signals

Any of these, from two or more contractors, warrants pausing to reconsider before continuing the sequence:

- They do not use WhatsApp for business at all in their market.
- Their customers do not answer SMS from unknown numbers.
- They have an office manager or partner who already chases every quote.
- Quote volume is under three per month — the maths does not support the retainer.

8. Schedule and cost

Week	Activity
Week 1, days 1–2	Build the recruit list. Three supplier trade counters, two association contacts, two trade groups. Target 15 approaches for 5 slots.
Week 1, days 3–5	Outreach and booking. Expect roughly one in three to convert. Offer evenings and Sundays.
Week 2	Run all five interviews. Write each up within the hour.
Week 2, end	Score against section 7. One page of findings, one decision.

Budget roughly GBP 250–400 in incentives, plus whatever a regional show or merchant visit costs. Timezone note: slot 3 (Australia) and slot 5 (EMEA) need early-morning or late-evening UK calls — book them first, as they are the hardest to schedule.

9. Conduct and compliance

- **Do not sell.** Stating "not selling anything" and then pitching destroys the referral chain this persona runs on, and regional trade networks talk.
- **Pay the incentive** within 24 hours regardless of how the call went.
- **Recording** requires explicit verbal consent at the start, captured on the recording itself.
- **GDPR from the first interview.** Interviewee details and any end-customer data shared during the live offer are personal data under UK and EU GDPR. Record a lawful basis, store it in one controlled place, set a retention limit, and delete on request. For the live offer specifically, get the contractor's written confirmation — a WhatsApp message is sufficient — that they are instructing you to contact their customer on their behalf.
- **Never contact a customer** from the live offer without showing the contractor every message first. One misfire here ends the relationship and the referral chain behind it.

10. What comes out of this

A one-page findings note answering exactly two questions — is the non-adoption thesis real, and does strict per-message gating survive the Sunday-night test — plus the decision from section 7, the verbatim red lines that become product guardrails, and ideally one or two live sequences running against real cold quotes.

That last item matters most. A reply from a real customer on a real dormant quote is worth more than all five interviews combined, and it is the demo that sells the next ten.